

EARLY MATCHLOCK GUNS

The matchlock was an early firing mechanism for handheld guns. It featured a device—the serpentine—that held a piece of smoldering match-cord. Upon pulling the trigger, the serpentine plunged the match-cord into a pan carrying priming powder. Ignition of the priming powder produced a flash, which ignited the main charge via a vent in the side of the barrel. Firing the gun by just pulling a trigger or squeezing a lever allowed the firer to focus on the target by looking down the barrel. Early matchlock guns were muzzle-loading. A wooden rod called a ramrod was used to ram the gunpowder charge and ball into the breech.

▲ SNAPPING MATCHLOCK

Date c.1540

Origin Italy

Barrel 42in (105cm)

Caliber .47in (12mm)

Henry VIII of England ordered 1,500 of these guns from the Venetian Republic in 1544. A year later, some of them were aboard his flagship, the *Mary Rose*, when it sank. Experiments have shown that their ammunition could penetrate up to $\frac{1}{4}$ in (6mm) of steel at 30 yards (27m).

